

that I had no idea what he was seeking from me. For about an hour, Jim staggered trying to put it together and pretty much gave up. As often happens with our minds, when he quit trying, it popped right out, and he said, “What are you doing that your competitors aren't doing yet?” What a great question! The emphasis was on the word *yet*. Staggering. Most folks, when you ask them that question, aren't doing one darned thing of any great significance their competitors aren't already doing and feel awestruck that you asked them this and they hadn't thought of it themselves.

The firm that is always asking itself that question never becomes complacent. It is never caught behind. It never starves for intellectual grist to chew through toward a better future. It is the firm that, coupled with integrity and raw management intellect, lives the fifteen points. “What are you doing that your competitors aren't doing yet?” implies driving the product market, forcing others to follow, and dominating for the betterment of customers, employees, and shareholders, which is sheer greatness. Jim's question both summed up my father's lifelong aspirations and summarized the gist of his fifteen points. And where he got it from I still don't know to this day. But it is a stunningly-cunning question.

Jim, who always had a nose for the twist that made a great story, returned to New York after our weekend and composed a *Forbes* article wrapped around that question. It combined the best of Jim and my father, and the whole thing reminded me of how often in my life I was the plodding, mechanical fly-wheel around my father's eclectic brilliance. I'm not meaning to demean myself. I've done very well in life; but I am more linear, more deductive, harder working, more driven, and more direct than my father, who was vastly more a non-linear genius.

My firm has applied the fifteen points and scuttlebutt to firms of most varieties, although primarily smaller, beat-up ones. Retailers, technology companies of various forms, service firms, concrete, steel, specialty chemicals, consumer products, gambling, you name it. The fifteen points hasn't always been the final decisive phenomena that compelled me or the firm, but they often added value. I've always felt free to pretty much do my own thing. While contemplating on a large scale and attempting to reach conclusions on hundreds of stock yearly, my firm mass-produced the process for many years in a process we called Twelve-Call, which was run off an operations manual with remote-location workers doing telephone